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CAUGHT IN THE MUDDLE

A global box-office success, Diljit Dosanjh's *Sardaar Ji 3* remains unreleased in India—a self-imposed restraint by its producers despite surprise backing from the BJP

By SUHANI SINGH & ANILESH S. MAHAJAN



CROSS-BORDER CONTROVERSY Diljit Singh with Hania Aamir in a still from *Sardaar Ji 3*

On the last weekend of June, a Punjabi horror-comedy film featuring a cross-border cast quietly shattered box-office records abroad. *Sardaar Ji 3*, starring Diljit Dosanjh, Neeru Bajwa and Pakistani actress Hania Aamir, grossed over $1.1 million (Rs 9.43 crore) in North America during its opening weekend. In the UK, it became the highest-grossing Punjabi film of the year, turning in £450,000 (Rs 5.29 crore) in just five days. It also saw sold-out shows in Pakistani cities like Lahore and Karachi, earning an estimated $500,000 (Rs 4.28 crore) on the first day itself. In doing so, the film beat Salman Khan-starrer *Sultan* to register the highest opening for an Indian film in Pakistan.

In India, though, *Sardaar Ji 3* was nowhere to be seen. Its producers had pulled the domestic release, well aware of the heightened sensitivities following the